

Q What's the best way to keep my baby clean each day?

Until your baby is on the move, crawling around and picking up dirt, a daily bath isn't vital, but you do need to give her a thorough cleaning, or sponge bath, each day.

This involves washing her face, bottom, and in the skin creases where dirt and spit-up milk accumulate. Get organized first, so you don't have to root around for diapers or cloths in the

middle of cleaning, and instead can give your baby your full attention so she doesn't become anxious and restless. See page 186 for the equipment you'll need for bathing your baby.

YOU WILL NEED

» **A bowl, or sink, of warm water.**

» **Some cotton pads** and a washcloth.

» **a clean diaper**, and diaper liner if you are using disposable diapers.

SPONGE BATHING YOUR BABY

Wash your hands before you start. Lay your baby down on her changing mat in a draft-free room. Put a towel on top of the mat for added comfort if you'd like. Then either undress your baby down to her undershirt and diaper, or if it's a bit chilly, keep her sleep suit on and undo the top and bottom half separately, keeping one half of her covered while you clean the other half.



1 Using a separate piece of damp cotton pad for each eye, gently wipe your baby's eyes from the inner to the outer edge. Use a new piece of cotton pad to clean behind (not inside) the ears and around the neck, cleaning out milk residue from skin creases.



2 Gently lift up your baby's arms and clean in her armpits; then clean the palm of your baby's hand and uncurl her fingers to clean in between each one. Wash your baby's feet, again gently cleaning between the toes, and clean her legs, wiping the creases under the knees.



3 Use a clean damp washcloth to clean around the umbilical cord area. You can use plain water, or mild baby soap if the area is dirty with feces. Pat the area dry and let air get to the skin. Then clean the diaper area (see p.283) before putting on a new diaper.

Q How can I dress my baby so that she isn't too hot or too cold?

Generally, the advice is for your baby to wear one more layer of clothing than you are wearing, which may just mean adding a onesie under a sleep suit and cardigan, or putting a blanket over her in the carriage. You should regularly check, though, whether your baby seems comfortable. Young babies aren't good at regulating their body temperature, and so rely on you to make sure they are just right. By dressing your baby in several lightweight layers, you can quickly adapt her clothing when you are moving between indoors and outdoors, perhaps adding a cotton blanket, or removing a jacket, as required. It's important, too, not to

leave your baby sleeping in outdoor layers when you get home, however tempting it may be not to disturb her, since she may overheat.

Gauge your baby's temperature by feeling her tummy, chest, or the nape of her neck—if these areas feel hot to touch, remove a layer, or add a layer if they feel cold. Keep in mind that babies' hands and feet are often on the cool side, so don't use these to judge temperature.

On sunny days, make sure your baby's shoulders are covered up and put a wide-brimmed sun hat on her. Your baby's skin is very delicate and can burn quickly, so in addition to keeping her covered, keep her out of direct sunshine during the part of the day when the sun is strongest. Use a sunshade on her carriage, and apply sunscreen that is specially formulated for babies, with a minimum of SPF 30.

Q What's the easiest way to put on my baby's onesie and sleep suit?

Onesies with envelope-style necks can be pulled wide, making them easy to pass over a baby's head. Lay your baby down, gently lift the back of her head, then pull the neckline over, lifting the fabric off her face. Pull each onesie arm out to pop her hands through, then smooth it over her body and close the snaps.

Lay the sleep suit out, snaps open, and place your baby on it. Gently bend her legs and place them in the sleep suit legs, then close the snaps around the legs and diaper area. Gather the fabric on an arm and pass her hand through the sleeve, putting your hand through the other end to guide it. Close the remaining snaps.